

Income Documentation Guide

Most landlords want gross income of about **3x the monthly rent**, verified on paper. Renters get denied every day not because they don't earn enough — but because they can't *prove* what they earn. This guide fixes that for every type of income.

If You're a W-2 Employee (regular paycheck)

- Your last 2–4 pay stubs (most recent first)
- Offer letter, if you started within 90 days (covers you before stubs build up)
- Last year's W-2 if your hours vary — it shows the full-year picture

Watch out: if you work variable hours, landlords annualize your **recent** stubs. If your last two weeks were slow, pull four stubs instead of two and include the W-2.

If You're a Gig Worker / 1099 / Self-Employed

Uber, DoorDash, Instacart, braiding hair, cutting grass, reselling — it all counts if you document it:

1. **Bank statements (3–6 months)**. The strongest proof you have. Highlight the deposits.
2. **Earnings screenshots** from each app (Uber/DD/IG have year-to-date summaries — export the official one, not a photo of your screen).
3. **Last year's tax return (1040 + Schedule C)** if you filed. This is the gold standard — and a reason to file even when not required.
4. **A simple profit summary**: one page listing monthly gross for the last 6 months with an average. Use the table below.

Month	Gross earnings	Source(s)
6-MONTH AVERAGE		

If You're Paid in Cash

Cash income is real income — but invisible cash is unprovable income. Starting today:

5. **Deposit your cash weekly** into a bank account, same day each week if you can. After 2–3 months you have a deposit pattern any landlord can read. (No bank account? Free/low-fee options exist — [MORGAN: link a no-fee banking option].)

6. **Get an employer letter:** one paragraph on letterhead or with contact info: “[Name] has worked for me as a [role] since [date] and earns approximately \$[X] per week.” Signed, dated, phone number.
7. **File taxes** even if you aren't required to — a tax return turns cash into documented income, and may qualify you for credits like the EITC anyway.

Benefits, Support & Other Income

These count as income, and a landlord rejecting them outright may be breaking Philadelphia law:

- **SSI / SSDI / VA benefits:** your annual award letter (download from ssa.gov / va.gov)
- **Child support / alimony:** court order plus 3 months of payment records (PA SCDU printout)
- **Pension / retirement:** benefit statement or 1099-R
- **Regular family support:** consistent monthly transfers + a signed letter from the supporter

If You Have a Housing Choice Voucher

Your math is different — and better than most renters realize. The landlord receives the voucher portion **directly from PHA, guaranteed, every month**. You only need to support **your** portion.

- Lead with the split: “Voucher pays \$X directly to you; my portion is \$Y, supported by [income].”
- Have your voucher paperwork in your document folder, ready to send same-day
- In Philadelphia, source-of-income discrimination is illegal — document refusals and report them [MORGAN: PCHR link]

If You're Short of 3x — Your Options, In Order

8. **Recalculate:** did you count ALL income? Second jobs, benefits, support — most people undercount.
9. **Add a cosigner** (see the Cosigner Request Kit in this package).
10. **Use a guarantor service** — a company cosigns for a one-time fee. [MORGAN: link]
11. **Show savings:** 3–6 months of rent in the bank changes the conversation with private landlords.
12. **Offer prepaid months or extra deposit** where lawful — PA caps security deposits at 2 months' rent in year one, so frame extra money as prepaid rent, not deposit.
13. **Target private landlords** over big property managers — humans can weigh the full picture; algorithms can't.